

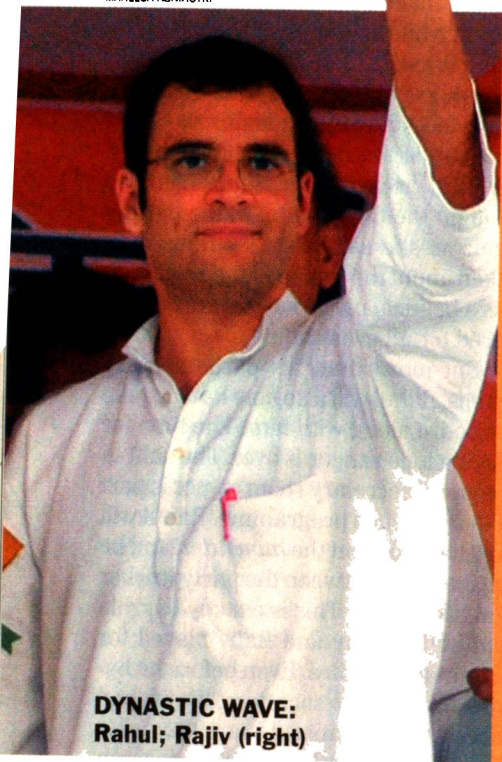
seasoned players like Digvijay Singh, Prithviraj Chavan and Veerappa Moily. Providing the crucial connectivity with the past are a few old-timers from Indira's Congress. For once, poaching has not been frowned upon. Earlier, it was only Fernandes who violated the one-man-one-post code by handling both ministerial and organisational responsibilities. Now, however, five ministers of state and a couple of cabinet ministers have been drafted for organisational duty with Chavan being made a general secretary.

The number of

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

Pradesh Congress Committees (PCCs) of Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Rajasthan and Uttarakhand, all of which were plagued by factional politics. The elevation of H.N. Bahuguna's daughter, Rita, as the Uttar Pradesh state chief seems to be a move to woo the party's traditional Brahmin votebank while the Rajasthan state chief was removed to appease Ashok Gehlot. The former chief minister was keen to return to his state and fight the polls due next year. This was refused but, as a sop, his bete noire B.D. Kala has been replaced with a Brahmin-Dalit combination of a PCC chief and a working president. Equally interesting is the one change that Sonia has not made.

locked up by Motilal Vora as it was being used more to plant stories against various factions within the Congress rather than draft any serious policy. This department now has been handed over to the more serious-minded Moily. More importantly, Sonia has also set up a new committee—the Group to Look into Future Challenges which also has Rahul on board. This group is expected to prepare the party's response to the issue of the day—be it the Ram Sethu controversy or quota politics. Until now, Rahul shirked from responding to any issue as he was scared that this might be construed as Sonia's view-



DYNASTIC WAVE:
Rahul; Rajiv (right)

MIRROR IMAGE

THE TIMING: Rajiv was 39 when he became general secretary in February 1983 while Rahul is 37. In addition to the youth wings, Rajiv handled the Seva Dal as well.

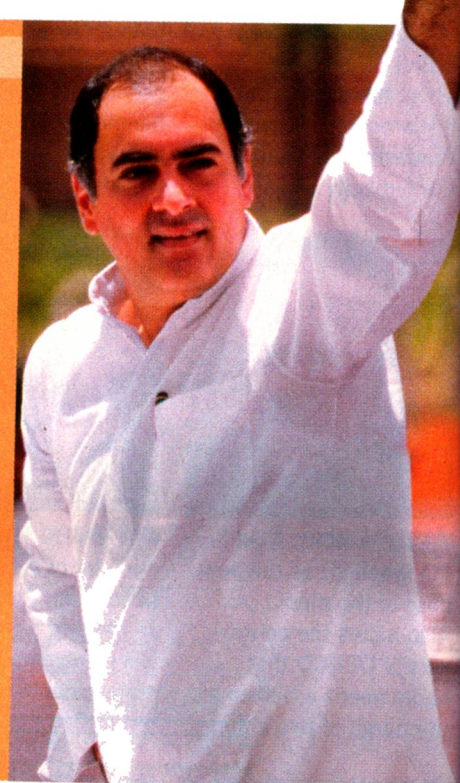
WORK EXPERIENCE: Rajiv had successfully organised the 1982 Asian Games while Rahul led the party's campaign in Uttar Pradesh.

INNER CIRCLE: Rajiv had two Aruns in his core team while Rahul has a band of young MPs working with him.

MOTHER'S PRIDE: While Rajiv entered politics to "help Mummy", Rahul is expected to eventually take over from his mother.

PARTY IN POWER: Both entered politics when the Congress has been in power. Of course, Indira was prime minister while Sonia is not.

CHIP OFF THE OLD BLOCK: Rahul has the same sartorial taste as his father. Wears loose kurta pyjamas, keds and speaks the public school language. Like Rajiv, he speaks his mind.



general secretaries too has increased from eight to an unwieldy 11, the largest ever. As a party general secretary explains, this is to ensure that no one is over-burdened. Regardless, some are more equal than others. One performer, who has been acknowledged and clearly marked for Team Rahul, is Digvijay, the former Madhya Pradesh chief minister. He has been handed over the task of crafting the much-needed electoral turnaround in a state which sends 80 MPs for the Lok Sabha: Uttar Pradesh.

It is not just the centre but the reshuffle has also extended to the

Madhya Pradesh state unit chief Subhash Yadav was tipped to be replaced. The state is due for polls next year along with Rajasthan, and has one Union minister and one young dynast lobbying to be the party's chief ministerial candidate. Making one of them PCC chief would have sent a signal as to which leader Sonia backed. For now, she seems to have decided to let this particular issue fester.

As with the UPA Government, the Congress president has put a lot of emphasis on the committee raj. The infamous DEPCO (Department of Policy Planning and Coordination) had been

point. Now that he holds a party position, he no longer has this excuse. This committee, in fact, is an ideal platform for him to come up with the first draft of the party's manifesto for the next polls.

Two months ago, when Rahul went to cast his vote for the presidential elections, he was mobbed by the media. He waved them away saying, "You always ask me the same question. Think of something new." Well, now that he has finally begun replying to a two-year-old question, it would be interesting to note the punctuation marks on his answer sheet.